

Asia and Australasia

Harappa

Location Punjab, Pakistan

Harappa, the first known city in south Asia, and one of the first in the world, was settled in around 3300 BCE. Stretching some 0.6 square miles (1.5 square km) along the Indus River Valley (in modern-day Pakistan), it is thought to have been home to around 24,000 people and been supported by local agriculture. The city was arranged in a grid pattern and included a distinctive citadel with crenellated walls, flat-roofed houses, granaries, halls, and sophisticated drainage and sanitation systems. Mud and baked brick were the primary building materials. Harappa was abandoned in around 1750 BCE, possibly as a result of rising sea levels and the silting up of rivers.

The Temple of Solomon

Location Jerusalem, Israel

The center of Jewish worship in ancient times, the Temple of Solomon was erected by King Solomon and stood from around 957 BCE until 587 CE, when it was destroyed by the Babylonians. The rectangular stone structure took 7 years to build and had three main areas: a porch, flanked by two huge bronze pillars; a main interior hall, overlaid with gold; and an even more sumptuous 30-ft- (9-m-) square gold-clad inner sanctum containing the Ark of the Covenant—a gold chest said to have housed two stone tablets of the Ten Commandments. The

two main rooms were paneled in carved cedar wood, with floorboards made from cypress. The cost of the spectacular temple is said to have been exorbitant.

Nimrud

Location near Mosul, Iraq

The city of Nimrud (formerly Kalhu) was founded in the 13th century BCE but did not rise to prominence until the 9th century BCE, when the Assyrian king Ashurnasirpal II rebuilt and expanded it as his capital. By 879 BCE, supported by a vast labor force, he had created a city of some 1.4 square miles (3.6 square km), with enormous defensive walls, temples, shrines, irrigation canals, and a distinctive ziggurat. The most impressive building was his Northwest Palace, which covered almost 322,917 square ft (30,000 square m) and contained breathtaking examples of Assyrian art, including vibrant frescoes and colossal limestone bas-reliefs and monuments. Nimrud was extended by successive rulers but was virtually abandoned in the 7th century BCE, when the Assyrian Empire fell.

Citadel of Van

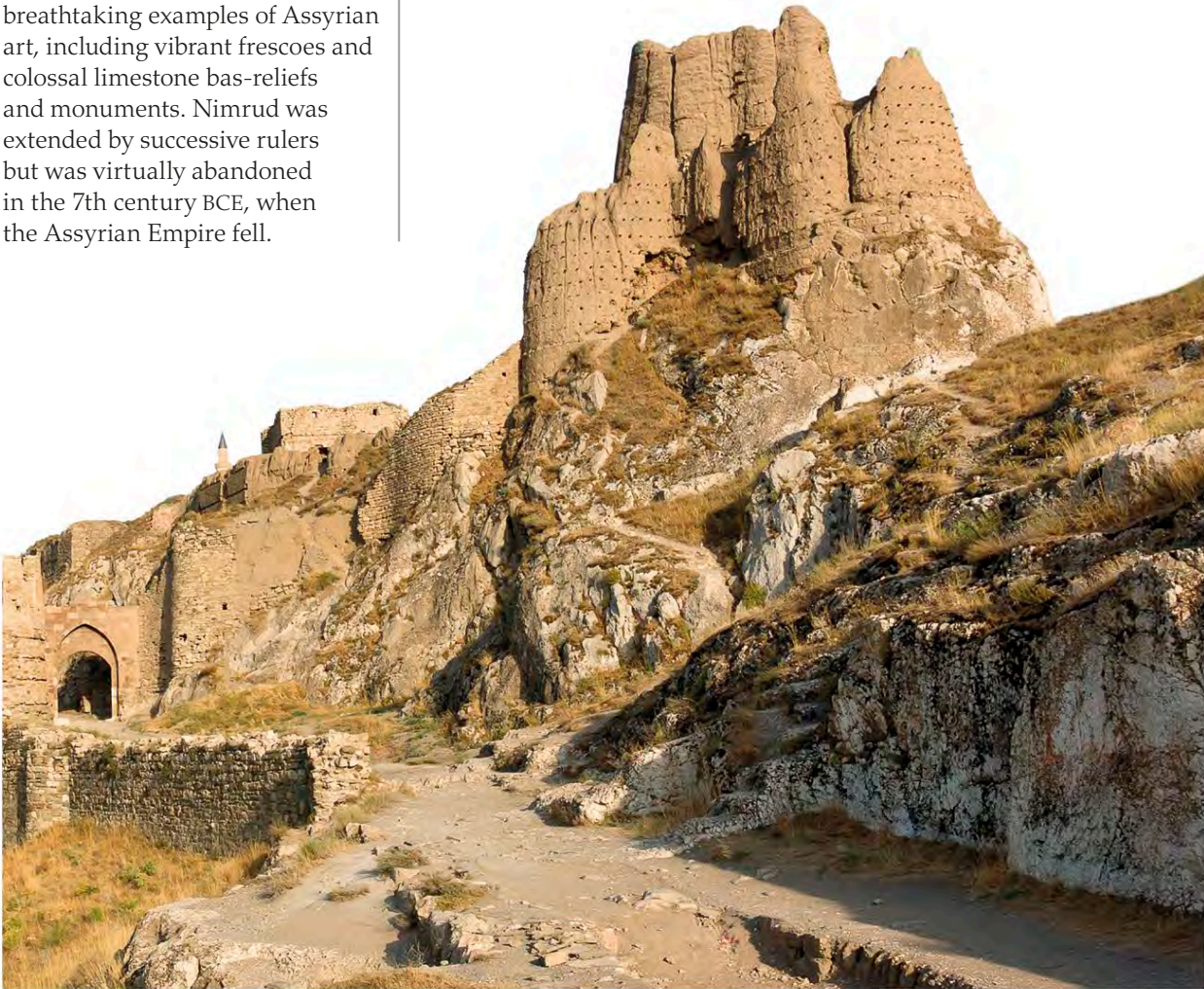
Location Van, Turkey

The Citadel of Van was a fortress town built by the Urartu Kingdom of ancient Armenia between the 9th and 7th centuries BCE. The imposing fortification was constructed on stepped terraces, high on a limestone promontory overlooking the Old City of Van (Tushpa), Lake Van, and the region's hugely fertile lands. The citadel's vast walls, made from mud-brick and unmortared basalt, were designed to facilitate control of regional territories rather than simply be a means of defense. Sardur Tower, built with huge limestone blocks in c.840–830 BCE, is thought to have been the first building on the site. Thereafter, the citadel was greatly expanded to include many impressive structures, including palaces, royal burial chambers, sanctuaries, canals, and inscribed stelae.

Palace of Sargon II

Location Khorsabad, Iraq

Constructed on a high terrace within the heavily fortified Assyrian capital city of Dur-Sharrukin (present-day Khorsabad), the palace of King Sargon II was dedicated in 706 BCE, the year before the king's death in battle. Two enormous limestone bulls almost 13 ft (4 m) high, with wings and human heads, guarded the entrance. The palace itself was also monumental in design, testimony to the might of the king. Built mainly from mud-brick, it included a spectacular entrance court, a state court, a throne room, and numerous halls and courtyards, some with pools. Among the decoration were bronze doors, carved ivory ceilings, and bas-reliefs on the walls depicting victories in battle. The royal enclosure included a multistoried ziggurat and temples dedicated to major deities.



► THE CITADEL OF VAN, LOCATED ON A LIMESTONE PROMONTORY